

Korea Daily Brief

Thursday, September 24, 2026

No. 183 · 3,485 words · 14 min read

RE: DPRK FM rejects denuclearization · Russia invites Kim to Moscow · Two NK POWs transferred to Seoul · 240mm MLRS upgraded

KOSPI
7,080.92
▲ +1.0%

USD/KRW
1,369.25
▲ +1.4%

BRENT
\$104.35
▲ +1.2%

BOK RATE
2.50%
Sep 2026

• TODAY AT A GLANCE

- 1 DPRK Foreign Minister Choe Son Hui declared Pyongyang's will to retain nuclear weapons 'irreversible through all ages,' directly rejecting a joint US-ROK-Japan denuclearization call at UNGA.
- 2 Ukraine transferred two North Korean prisoners of war to South Korea, President Zelensky announced, marking the first confirmed transfer of DPRK POWs to Seoul from the Kursk incursion.
- 3 Russia's Deputy Foreign Minister Andrei Rudenko confirmed Moscow has formally invited Kim Jong Un to visit Russia, with the schedule to be coordinated through diplomatic channels.

• TOP STORIES

DPRK

DPRK FM Choe Son Hui rejects US-ROK-Japan denuclearization call as 'unrealistic,' vows to keep nuclear weapons 'forever'

North Korean Foreign Minister **Choe Son Hui** issued a statement through KCNA on Thursday rejecting the joint US-ROK-Japan call for Pyongyang to denuclearize and return to dialogue, declaring the country's will to retain nuclear weapons is 'unchanged' and 'irreversible through all ages.' The statement came the same day Russia formally invited Kim Jong Un to Moscow and one day after Trump reaffirmed commitment to dialogue with North Korea in his meeting with President Lee. Choe's statement preempts any diplomatic opening the US-China summit this week might generate for Korean Peninsula diplomacy.

NK News · Yonhap · Bloomberg

NK-RUSSIA-CHINA

Ukraine transfers two North Korean POWs to South Korea; Zelensky announces at UNGA

Ukrainian President **Volodymyr Zelensky** announced Wednesday that Ukraine had transferred two North Korean soldiers — captured during its incursion into Russia's Kursk region in early 2025 — to South Korea.

Russia stated it had no information on the transfer, while SBS reported Seoul may have provided weapons aid to Ukraine in exchange. The two POWs are the first confirmed DPRK soldiers transferred to Seoul, providing direct intelligence on DPRK troop deployment, training, and order-of-battle in Russia.

NK News · NYT · Reuters · AP · WaPo

DPRK

North Korea tests upgraded 240mm MLRS, claims extended range; weapons to be deployed to South Korean border

KCNA reported Thursday that North Korea successfully tested an upgraded 240mm multiple-launch rocket system (MLRS) on Tuesday, with top military officials overseeing the test. State media said the weapons will be deployed to the South Korean border 'to constantly expose the enemy to extreme uneasiness and fear.' The test follows the Sep 21 hypersonic-linked weapons test overseen by Kim Jong Un, constituting two kinetic demonstrations in three days.

NK News · Reuters · Yonhap

• OVERNIGHT

TRILATERAL	US announces SMR deployment implementation plan with South Korea and Japan · Yonhap English First trilateral civil nuclear implementation framework announced.
US-KOREA	White House confirms Lee-Trump New York meeting covered shipbuilding and 'other topics' · Yonhap English White House official confirms warship cooperation was on the agenda.
DPRK	North Korean cybercriminals using new malware to target Ukraine-focused organizations · NKPro SOCRadar attributes 'Operation Conflict Compass' to DPRK threat actors.
US-KOREA	ROK Prime Minister Han meets US Ambassador to discuss alliance strengthening · Yonhap English Follows new Defense Minister Kang's appointment earlier this week.
NK-RUSSIA-CHINA	Russia formally invites Kim Jong Un to visit — schedule to be set via diplomatic channels · Investing.com Deputy FM Rudenko cited the June 2024 Comprehensive Strategic Partnership Treaty.
DPRK	North Korea's vice defense minister departs for Vietnam amid deepening bilateral ties · 뉴시스 / 동아일보 Departure confirmed by KCNA; parallel to DPRK Vice FM attending UNGA.

• STAT OF THE DAY

600 km

Range of upgraded 240mm MLRS shells tested by DPRK

KCNA reported North Korea's upgraded 240mm multiple-launch rocket system achieved extended range, with state media explicitly saying the weapons will be deployed to the South Korean border to 'constantly expose the enemy to extreme uneasiness and fear.'

NK News / KCNA, Sep 24 2026

PYONGYANG WATCH · KCNA

KIM JONG UN

WATCH FLAG

● **No appearance (2d since last)**

TOP KCNA ARTICLES

1. North Korea's Foreign Minister declares nuclear weapons retention irreversible, rejects denuclearization

FM Choe Son Hui issued a KCNA statement saying North Korea's will to keep nuclear weapons is 'unchanged' and 'irreversible through all ages,' directly rejecting the US-ROK-Japan joint call. — KCNA (Yonhap)

2. North Korea tests upgraded 240mm multiple-launch rocket system; weapons to target South Korean border

KCNA reported Tuesday's successful test of an upgraded 240mm MLRS, claiming range extension and announcing deployment to the South Korean border to 'constantly expose the enemy to extreme uneasiness and fear.' — KCNA (NK News)

3. DPRK Vice Foreign Minister departs for New York to attend UN General Assembly

KCNA confirmed Vice FM Kim Son-gyong departed for New York to attend UNGA, arriving the same day FM Choe Son Hui issued the nuclear irreversibility statement. — KCNA (Yonhap)

SENIOR OFFICIALS

Choe Son Hui · Foreign Minister

Issued KCNA statement rejecting US-ROK-Japan denuclearization call, declaring North Korea's nuclear weapons status irreversible 'through all ages.'

Kim Son-gyong · Vice Foreign Minister

Departed for New York to attend the UN General Assembly high-level week.

Bottom line: KCNA's dominant output today is FM Choe Son Hui's blanket nuclear irreversibility declaration paired with the 240mm MLRS upgrade announcement — kinetic and diplomatic tracks both escalating simultaneously. Watch Kim Son-gyong's UNGA statement and any Punggye-ri seismic activity.

● **ROK GOVERNMENT**

President + Ministries · Thursday, September 24, 2026

국방부 · MINISTRY OF NATIONAL DEFENSE

Defense Minister visits frontline 7th Infantry Division on Chuseok holiday

Minister Kang Shin-chul

외교부 · MINISTRY OF FOREIGN AFFAIRS

ROK FM pledges continued support for Ukraine in bilateral talks

FM Cho Hyun

Minister **Kang Shin-chul** visited the Army's 7th Infantry Division on the central-eastern front on Sep 24, receiving operational briefings at the GOP battalion command and inspecting troops' living conditions. He ordered troops to be 'rough, relentless, and lethal' toward the enemy and said any provocation should be met with resolute response as if the minister himself had given the order.

Primary 뉴스스 ↗

대통령실 · BLUE HOUSE / PRESIDENT'S OFFICE

Lee pledges to double chip production in five years and build disruption-free AI supply chains

President Lee Jae-myung

President **Lee Jae-myung** made the chip production pledge in New York on the sidelines of the UN General Assembly. He separately discussed warship construction cooperation with President Trump, according to a White House official cited by Reuters.

Primary Yonhap EN ↗

Foreign Minister **Cho Hyun** pledged continued South Korean support for Ukraine during foreign ministerial talks, according to Yonhap. The meeting occurred on the margins of the UN General Assembly high-level week in New York.

Primary Yonhap EN ↗

PERSONNEL CHANGES

Kang Shin-chul **APPOINTED**

Minister of National Defense

Kang Shin-chul was confirmed as the new Defense Minister; the US Ambassador to ROK and USFK Commander Gen. Brunson attended his inauguration and discussed ways to further strengthen the US-ROK alliance, per the US Ambassador's post on X. Kang conducted a frontline visit to the 7th Infantry Division on the first day of the Chuseok holiday.

NATIONAL ASSEMBLY

DP continues criticism of Supreme Court Chief Justice Cho Hee-dae over re-nomination refusal

Democratic Party (ruling)

The Democratic Party's spokesperson accused Chief Justice **Cho Hee-dae** of acting as a 'politician' rather than a judicial administrator, alleging he ignored the Court Administration Office's views when refusing to re-recommend a Supreme Court justice nominee sought by the presidential office. The party called the refusal an unconstitutional overreach.

• US-KOREA TRADE & INVESTMENT

Steel and aluminium remain at 50% and autos at 15%, both under Section 232. The Section 122 surcharge expired July 24, leaving no baseline reciprocal tariff in place. Section 301 investigations launched in March 2026 are now the primary prospective vehicle for any new measures.

TARIFFS

EXPIRED

Section 122 surcharge lapsed Jul 24; Section 301 now primary tariff vehicle; sector 232 rates still in force.

WATCH THIS DATE
next trigger: Section 301 determination — pending, no fixed date

SECTOR RATES			
Steel & Aluminum		SECTION 232	50%
Copper		SECTION 232	50%
Automobiles & Auto Parts		SECTION 232	15%
Timber / Lumber / Wood Derivatives		SECTION 232	15%
Semiconductors (advanced logic)	SECTION 232 (PROCLAMATION 11002)		25%
Pharmaceuticals		SECTION 232	up to 15%
Civil Aircraft & Parts	US-KOREA DEAL EXEMPTION		0%
Generic Pharma / Precursors / Rare Natural Resources	ALIGNED PARTNERS LIST		0%

NEW THIS WEEK

US announces SMR deployment implementation plan with South Korea and Japan New deal

The US announced a trilateral implementation plan for small modular reactor deployments with South Korea and Japan on the sidelines of the UN General Assembly high-level week.
US, ROK, JAPAN · YONHAP ENGLISH

FULL TRADE REFERENCE →

Investment ledger, pledge tracker and standing policy measures.

BUSINESS & ECONOMY

TECH · YONHAP ENGLISH
Lee pledges to double South Korea's chip production in five years and build AI supply chains free of disruption
President Lee made the pledge in New York on the sidelines of UNGA, framing the target as insulating global AI infrastructure from single-point supply disruptions. The pledge follows the July 2026 San Francisco AI Summit LOIs and MOUs worth a reported ~\$950B.
Samsung Electronics SK Hynix

MANUFACTURING · NIKKEI KOREA

Starbucks' South Korean rivals gain market share from Starbucks marketing misstep

South Korean coffee chains are gaining customers following a Starbucks marketing error in the Korean market, a Nikkei analysis finds.

Starbucks Korea

NORTHEAST ASIA WATCH

CHINA-KOREA · CHINA-DIPLOMATIC · YONHAP ENGLISH

Trump gives Xi rare welcome at military base on eve of high-stakes Washington summit

President Trump welcomed Chinese President **Xi Jinping** at a US military base on the eve of their summit — a ceremonial gesture rare in US-China protocol. The summit's outcome on North Korea, Taiwan, and trade will directly affect Seoul's diplomatic calculus.

TRILATERAL · IISS

IISS: How South Korea can strengthen US shipbuilding — from yard to fleet

IISS analysis outlines how South Korean shipyard capacity can deepen the US alliance on naval MRO and new construction, directly relevant to the Lee-Trump warship cooperation discussion confirmed by the White House on Sep 23.

PUBLIC SENTIMENT

PRESIDENTIAL APPROVAL

37%

▼ 1 pts vs 2026-09-11

Gallup Korea · September 18, 2026

42% since Aug 25-27 ↓ 37% across 4 readings

RULING
Democratic

39%

OPPOSITION
People Power

25%

INDEPENDENTS

26%

Gallup Korea Spotlight September 18, 2026

Presidential approval at new low: President Lee Jae-myung's approval fell to 37% in the September 18 Gallup Korea weekly poll, down from 38% the prior week and below his previous low of 42% recorded in August.

UPCOMING

Oct
1

ROK Armed Forces Day (국군의 날)

Also the anniversary of the ROK-US Mutual Defense Treaty, signed in Washington on 1 October 1953. Recent years have brought a parade through central Seoul and new systems shown publicly; alliance statements from both capitals usually land the same day.

Oct
3

National Foundation Day (개천절)

Public holiday: KRX closed, ministries dark, no Assembly business. Expect a thin domestic news flow and few primary-source releases.

Oct
9

Hangul Day (한글날)

Public holiday: KRX closed, ministries dark. Falling within a week of 개천절, the two often bracket a slow stretch for government news.

Oct
10

Workers' Party founding day

The party was founded on this date in 1945. Decennial anniversaries have brought large Kim Il Sung Square parades and new systems shown in public for the first time; watch pre-event imagery for assembly.

• THE WIRE

NK-RUSSIA-CHINA

NKPRO

Likely Russian ship docks at Rason arms-trade port for first time since May — satellite imagery

NK Pro satellite imagery analysis shows a likely Russian cargo vessel at Rason's arms export berth on Sunday, ending a roughly four-month gap in observed visits. The Rason berth is the documented embarkation point for the ~15,800 container munitions transfers tracked in the CSIS NK-Russia database.

TRILATERAL

WAR ON THE ROCKS

South Korea's Deliberate Strategic Ambiguity on Taiwan

A War on the Rocks revisit of Seoul's Taiwan contingency posture finds that five years of US-ROK dialogue have not produced a clear South Korean commitment to involvement in a Taiwan scenario.

DPRK

NK NEWS

Kenneth Bae on surviving North Korean detention: 735 days, 17 prior visits, and what DPRK security revealed

Kenneth Bae's account of detention — captured during one of 17 North Korea visits — surfaces as South Korea receives two DPRK POWs and Pyongyang hardens its nuclear posture.

• ANALYSIS

OFFICIALS ON X

Ministry of National Defense (@ROK_MND) @ROK_MND

“Defense Minister Kang Shin-chul visited the frontline Army 7th Infantry Division on September 24 to inspect combat readiness and encourage troops serving during the Chuseok holiday. He ordered that troops 'must be rough, relentless, and lethal toward the enemy' and that any provocation should be met with resolute response.”

Context: Visit follows the Sep 21 DMZ mine blast that injured three ROK personnel from the 25th Division; forensic analysis of mine fragments is ongoing.

[View on X →](#)

US Ambassador to ROK (@USAmbROK) @USAmbROK

“I congratulate Minister Kang Shin-chul on his appointment; glad USFK Commander Brunson could join me. We discussed ways to further strengthen our ironclad US-ROK Alliance and shared our concern for the ROK personnel injured at the DMZ. We are keeping them in our thoughts and prayers and wish them a speedy recovery.”

Context: Post confirms USFK Commander Brunson attended the new Defense Minister's inauguration meeting alongside the US Ambassador, signaling continuity of alliance coordination.

[View on X →](#)

Direct posts by tracked official accounts, attributed as posted. Not independently verified beyond the post.



Kang Shin-chul

ROK Minister of National Defense

“The enemy must be rough, relentless, and lethal toward us — and if they provoke or intrude, respond decisively as if I had given the order myself.”

Analyst: Kang delivered this order to troops at the 7th Infantry Division's GOP command during his Chuseok holiday frontline visit; forensic analysis of the Sep 21 DMZ mine blast fragments is ongoing.

[Source →](#)



Lee Jae-myung

President of the Republic of Korea

“Combining South Korea's technology with Mexico's industrial base can create new growth.”

Analyst: Lee made the statement upon arrival in Mexico City for a state visit with President Sheinbaum; cooperation targets include AI, digital, aerospace, and defense industries.

[Source →](#)

COMMENTARY

CSIS

The Impossible State Live Podcast: Lips and Teeth? China, North Korea, and the Korean Peninsula

A CSIS Impossible State live podcast examines the evolving China-North Korea relationship against the backdrop of deepening NK-Russia military cooperation. The episode surfaces on the same day Russia formally invited Kim Jong Un to Moscow and DPRK FM Choe Son Hui rejected US-ROK-Japan denuclearization calls.

SEJONG INSTITUTE

[Sejong Policy Studies 2026-04] The U.S. Indo-Pacific Intermediate-Range Missile Deployment Strategy and the Korean Peninsula: The Frontline of

Sejong Institute's policy study examines the implications of the US Indo-Pacific intermediate-range missile deployment strategy for South Korea's security posture. The study's frontline framing is reinforced by today's DPRK 240mm MLRS upgrade announcement targeting the South Korean border.

• SATELLITE & LOCATION WATCH

3 of 11 sites at elevated or alert status

NK NEWS / NK PRO · SEP 21-22, 2026 — RUSSIAN SHIP AT RASON PORT — FIRST VISIT SINCE MAY

Likely Russian cargo vessel docks at Rason arms-trade port for first time since May, per satellite imagery analysis.

NK Pro analysis of satellite imagery shows a likely Russian cargo vessel appeared at Rason in northeastern DPRK on Sunday, marking the first such visit since May 2026. Rason's arms export berth has been the documented embarkation point for munitions shipments tracked in the CSIS NK-Russia transfer database. The gap since May — roughly four months — contrasts with the near-continuous activity observed in 2024-2025.

→ Rason SEZ · Vostochny/Dunai (Russian Far East)

NK Pro: Likely Russian ship docks in Rason ↗

ELEVATED ▲

Yongbyon Nuclear Complex

IAEA confirmed North Korea built a new uranium enrichment facility at Yongbyon (Reuters/CNN, Sep 9-10, 2026), assessed capable of producing material for up to four additional warheads annually (조선일보). Russia dismissed the IAEA report at the Vienna session, citing lack of access. Apr 2026: Enrichment building expansion complete, new centrifuge hall operational. 5 MWe reactor and IRT-2000 both running. Thermal signatures consistent with increased plutonium/HEU production.

imagery as of 2026-09-10

ACTIVITY ▲

Punggye-ri Nuclear Test Site

Nov 2025: ROK DIA assessed Tunnel No. 3 is test-ready and a nuclear test can be conducted at any time upon political decision. Site maintained at high readiness since mid-2024. Sep 9, 2016 fifth nuclear test 10-year anniversary fell three days ago; post-anniversary period historically carries elevated test risk. CNN/Yonhap reported Sep 18 that nearly 1,400 seismic events have been detected near the site since the 2017 test.

imagery as of 2026-09-18

ALERT ▲

Tumangang–Khasan (NK-Russia border)

Sep 8, 2026: The first road bridge over the Tumen River between North Korea and Russia was formally opened at a ceremony attended by Russian PM Mikhail Mishustin; the bridge is named after Soviet officer Yakov Novichenko. This constitutes a new permanent road link across the shared border, the first of its kind. NK News reporting confirms North Korea remains closed to private car travel via the bridge; crossings are limited to organized bus tours per the Association of Tour Operators of Russia (ATOR). NBC News analysis (Sep 15) frames the bridge alongside the near-complete Sinuiju-Dandong crossing as dual infrastructure bets by Pyongyang.

imagery as of 2026-09-15

ACTIVITY ▲

Sinuiju–Dandong (NK-China border)

Sep 21, 2026: ROK Embassy in Beijing confirmed the cargo carried by heavy trucks crossing the new Yalu River bridge on Sep 17 consisted of air-conditioning units (HVAC equipment) destined for the customs building, indicating construction is roughly 70-80% complete. Embassy source said the bridge could open approximately one month after building completion following a trial period, with the NK-China diplomatic anniversary (Oct 6) cited as a possible opening date. DPRK national insignia already installed on the North Korean customs building.

imagery as of 2026-09-21

ACTIVITY ▲

Rason SEZ

ACTIVITY ▲

Vostochny/Dunai (Russian Far East)

Sep 21-22, 2026: NK Pro satellite imagery analysis shows a likely Russian cargo vessel docked at Rason for the first time since May 2026 — a roughly four-month gap after near-continuous activity in 2024-2025. Nov 2025: Chinese businesspeople re-entry to Rason SEZ expanded. Coal exports through Rason at highest levels in years throughout 2025. Arms export berth also active.

imagery as of 2026-09-22

Jan 2026: Arms shipments slowed due to ice — one Russian vessel (likely Angara or Lady R) visited Rason, docked Jan 14 at arms export berth. Cargo routed to Vostochny. Since Sep 2023: 64 voyages by 4 vessels (Angara, Maria, Maya-1, Lady R) delivered ~15,800 containers (~4.2-5.8M munitions) from Rajin to Vostochny/Dunai. Road bridge now open Sep 8, 2026, providing first permanent road route to supplement existing rail. NK News satellite imagery (Sep 18) shows ongoing upgrades to DPRK urban warfare training facilities consistent with troops rotating back from Russia.

imagery as of 2026-09-18

5 other monitored sites: no new imagery in the last 30 days · oldest report 2025-05.

CSIS

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